

Working-session *synthesis*

Meeting #7 · July 17, 2026 — dates on the board.

Meeting #7 · Friday July 17, 2026. Present: Mario Ramos (Chairperson) and Pedro Rosa (Facilitator). A two-person working call; Munchie, Elliott, and the older mentor group referenced but not present. **Format:** Recorded working call — a short agenda (summer trip, ballgame) opened by a retrospective on the Washington send-off purchases. Closed with Pedro to write up the notes and circulate them so the committee is on the same page.

TL;DR

Two things locked and one important correction. The **ballgame is set: August 28**, an evening game on the South Side, \$10 tickets through Elliott — and it's grown from a small outing into the year's first **family event**, with parents, siblings, and the older college-age mentors all invited, meeting at Humboldt Park with a possible tailgate. The **summer retreat moved to the weekend of August 7–9** and Mario is calling to lock it; the committee also **re-confirmed the Wisconsin lodge over a closer Illinois alternative**, deliberately choosing the rustic option because it has the outdoor group space — campfire, bags, room to sit under the stars — that the whole point of the trip depends on. That choice carries real logistics: **the cabins have no beds**, so the committee supplies sleeping bags and air mattresses rather than pushing any cost onto parents. **Correction to the record: the retreat was never actually booked for Aug 16–17** — the lodge called back asking for a date, so the July 1 entry was premature (see §1). On money, the account sits at ~\$634 with a **corporate contribution of \$1,000–\$2,000 expected within days**, comfortably covering the ~\$1,200 all-in retreat estimate. The send-off purchasing produced two durable operating lessons — **get the list early and don't gate ordering on the next meetup**, and **pair any scholar without at-home support with an adult to shop with** — and the two scholars depart this Sunday.

1. Correction to the record — the retreat was not booked

The July 1 synthesis recorded the retreat as "**booked for August 16–17**" with a 20% deposit. That was premature. The lodge subsequently **called Mario back to ask whether he had chosen a date**, which means no reservation was ever held. Nothing was lost — the dates were still open — but the canon and the live plan page both need correcting.

Two related details also changed:

- **Dates:** now targeting **August 7–9** (Fri–Sun), not Aug 16–17.
- **Deposit:** the lodge takes **half** up front, not 20%.
- **Cancellation:** once locked, changes require **21 days' notice** or the deposit is forfeited — and the committee is already close to that window, which is the reason for moving quickly.

Plan-page implication: the summer-trip card currently reads "Booked · August 16–17." It should read as locking Aug 7–9. Flagged for the next plan update rather than changed silently.

2. Summer retreat — venue re-confirmed, dates chosen

The venue question got a real second look. Mario had called an alternative — a lodge in the Starved Rock / Ottawa area — and laid out the trade-off honestly:

	Wisconsin lodge (the lead)	Starved Rock / Ottawa (alternative)
Drive	~3 hours	~1 hr 20 min
Sleeping	One large cabin, fits ~10 — everyone together	Adjoining 4-person rooms, 2 queen beds each
Cost	~\$500 for two nights	Roughly double the lodging (more rooms needed)
Outdoor group space	Yes — campfire, bags, river	No — a nice indoor lodge lobby, but no outdoor space of their own
Activity	Canoeing on site	Vermilion River outfitters ~25 min away; hiking and trails

Decision: stay with the Wisconsin lodge. The closer option was cheaper on drive time but roughly double on lodging and — decisively — has **no outdoor space for the group to claim as their own**. The committee was explicit that the campfire, the bags, sitting outside and talking under the stars is not a nice-to-have; it's the mechanism the whole trip runs on. Being able to hang out, talk, and fish by the river is the reason for going.

Dates: targeting **August 7–9** (Fri/Sat/Sun). The following weekend (Aug 14–16) was also available but would have required **two cabins instead of the single one that sleeps ten** — splitting the group, which defeats the purpose. School starts **August 24**, so earlier is better. Both committee members had personal commitments on those weekends and both independently concluded they'd move them — the operating lesson from July 1 (*lock the date, let people arrange around it*) held.

Cost: roughly **\$200/night** plus about **\$8 per person**, landing near **\$480–\$500 plus tax** for two nights. Canoeing runs about **\$65/person** — call it \$600–\$700 for a group of ten. **All-in estimate: ~\$1,200**, deliberately on the high side.

Next step (Mario): call the lodge to lock **Aug 7–9**, pay the deposit, then post the confirmed dates to the group chat.

3. Retreat logistics — rustic by choice

Choosing the Wisconsin lodge means accepting real camping conditions, which the committee walked through deliberately so nothing surprises anyone:

- **No beds in the cabins.** Sleeping bags or air mattresses required. Twin air mattresses run ~\$20; Pedro already has a couple at the house.
- **Sleeping bags — committee-supplied.** Once there's a head count, Mario will buy used sleeping bags (~\$5 each) and launder them at a large-machine laundromat before the trip. The stated principle: **don't push equipment costs onto the parents.** This is the same reasoning behind the group t-shirts and the send-off cap — the initiative absorbs the cost so participation never depends on a family's budget.
- **Facilities:** gas lanterns provided in the cabins; a sink with running water; outhouse-style bathrooms behind each cabin (male and female); communal showers by the main building; a full kitchen across the way for breakfast, lunch, and dinner. Towels are provided; bedding is not.
- **Evenings:** campfire, bags, and the river for fishing.

Next step: collect the head count, then buy and launder the sleeping bags.

4. Ballgame — locked for August 28

What began as the lightest of the four initiatives has turned into the year's first **family-facing event**.

- **Date: Friday, August 28** — an evening game (roughly 6 PM start), moved up from a previously expected late-July date. Mario has the physical ticket at home and will photograph it to confirm the exact start time.
- **Venue:** the South Side ballpark.
- **Tickets: \$10 each**, sourced through Elliott — cheap enough that the invitation could be opened up widely.
- **Who's coming:** the scholars, plus **parents and families** (several asked to join), plus the **older college-age young men** who have been around the gym. Expected to be a sizeable group.
- **Transportation:** meet at **Humboldt Park**; Pedro will drive a truck with a third bench to carry a group.
- **Possible tailgate** beforehand, pending the confirmed start time.

Why this matters beyond the outing: it's the first occasion where the committee, the scholars, the parents, and the older mentors are all in one place. That's a relationship-building opportunity in both directions — the committee meets the families, and the younger scholars see slightly-older young men doing well. It's worth treating as more than a ballgame.

(Note: the game falls in the first week of school. Because it's an evening game, this was judged workable.)

5. Washington send-off — retrospective and two operating lessons

The purchasing round is essentially complete; the two scholars **depart Sunday**. Items were ordered, some were returned, and the process produced durable process knowledge:

Returns. Amazon returns can be dropped at a Whole Foods counter in the original packaging without boxing — the simplest of the offered routes. Refund timing was ambiguous (the counter suggested about a week; the policy language allows substantially longer). Filed as practical knowledge for future purchasing rounds.

Lesson 1 — Don't gate ordering on the next meetup. The list took about a week to come back, and then Mario wanted a group conversation before ordering, which compressed everything against the departure date. The improved flow for next time: **get the list immediately → allocate the budget → have them order**, without waiting for the next gathering. The committee now understands the operational rhythm well enough that each round shouldn't need a meeting to unblock it.

Lesson 2 — Pair scholars who lack at-home support. One scholar had help from a committee member and was fine. Another had no real idea how to approach it, and Mario ended up building the list with him in person — which turned out to be the right call for a reason that generalizes: **when someone else builds the list, sizing accuracy is lost**, and a wrong size close to departure means a scramble to exchange. The adopted practice: **assess whether a scholar has support at home, and if not, pair them with a committee member or a volunteer for an afternoon** to sit and shop together. This preserves the scholar's autonomy in choosing while ensuring the order is actually right.

Idea parked for next year: rather than ordering per-scholar, order **a range of suits in multiple sizes up front**, let the young men come try them on in person, and return what isn't used. Saves time and solves sizing directly. Logged for the next send-off cycle.

Next step (Mario): confirm the scholars have everything before Sunday; ask them to **take good photographs** — in their suits, at the Capitol — for the archive and the site.

6. Banking & budget

- **Current balance: ~\$634** (including a \$100 family gift, with a \$100 refund still in transit).
- **Incoming: a corporate contribution of \$1,000–\$2,000**, expected within days — Pedro is updating the site and coordinating with his contact. This comfortably covers the ~\$1,200 retreat estimate plus the deposit.
- **Additional cards — decided.** The Chase account supports up to two additional authorized users. The committee will add **at least one more card, in Munchie's name**, so Mario isn't the only person who can transact. For anyone without a card, the fallback stands: **pay, keep the receipt, submit a photo, get reimbursed** — the receipt image is the record.

7. Older mentors — the "middle ground"

Several college-age young men connected to the gym have asked to join both the retreat and the ballgame. The committee sees real value here and named it explicitly: a **20-to-22-year-old sits close**

enough to the scholars' world to be credible, and information about what's coming — college, work, decisions — lands differently from someone a few years ahead than from an adult. Mario has asked them to confirm.

Worth noting as an emerging structural idea: this is the beginning of a **peer-mentor tier** within the initiative, rather than a one-off. No decision needed now, but it's a pattern to watch as the cohort ages.

Action items

Mario (Chairperson) – Call the lodge and lock Aug 7–9; pay the deposit (half up front); post confirmed dates to the group chat. – Photograph the **ballgame ticket** to confirm the exact start time; coordinate the \$10 tickets through Elliott. – Collect the **retreat head count**, then buy and launder the **sleeping bags**. – Add a **second authorized-user card** in Munchie's name. – Confirm the send-off scholars are set before **Sunday**; ask for **photographs** from the trip. – Confirm which of the older mentors are joining the retreat and the ballgame.

Pedro (Facilitator) – Write up and circulate these notes so the whole committee is aligned. – Update the site and finalize the **corporate contribution** (\$1,000–\$2,000) in the next few days. – Bring **air mattresses**; drive the group from Humboldt Park to the ballgame. – **Correct the canon and the plan page** on the retreat dates (Aug 7–9, not Aug 16–17).

Committee – Apply the new **pair-up rule** on the next purchasing round: assess support at home, pair where absent. – Invite **families** to the August 28 ballgame.

Open decisions (status)

#	Item	Status
1	Retreat venue	Resolved — Wisconsin lodge re-confirmed over the closer alternative; outdoor group space was decisive
2	Retreat dates	Locking — targeting Aug 7–9; Mario calling to confirm and deposit
3	Ballgame	Resolved — Aug 28, evening game, \$10 tickets, families invited
4	Additional debit cards	Resolved — add one more in Munchie's name; receipts-and-reimbursement otherwise
5	Send-off purchasing process	Resolved (lessons adopted) — list early, order without waiting for a meetup; pair unsupported scholars
6	Bulk-suit approach for next year	Parked — order a size range, try on in person, return the rest
7	Consent-form e-signature / form digitization	Open — carried forward; Pedro researching
8	Instagram launch	Open — carried forward; send-off and retreat photos give it content

#	Item	Status
9	Fundraising goal	Held open — corporate gift covers the summer; revisit for the next cycle
10	Peer-mentor tier (older young men)	Emerging — no decision needed; watch as the cohort ages
11	EOS as a meeting framework	Parked — backlog

Two dates locked, a venue chosen for the right reason, and a first event where the families come too.